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by kirallea

Summary

Catra only has one wish for her birthday -- to see the world with Adora. Together, they set out on a hitchhiking adventure across Etheria, exploring new places and meeting new people.

Chapter 1

"So, birthday girl," Adora says, tapping her foot against Catra's leg. "What does it feel like to be officially old?"

Catra snorts and shoves an elbow into Adora's side, making her jerk away with a laugh.

"Shouldn't I be the one asking this question? You've been twenty for, what? Nine months?"

Adora leans back against Catra, snakes an arm around her waist. Catra gives herself permission to relax and melts into the touch, shoulders sinking with her exhale.

"It's okay," Adora says. "I don't feel old at all. Just a little more -- mature, maybe? I think it's the freedom that comes with turning twenty. People don't really tell you what to do anymore, not like they did before. It's pretty cool but also a little scary, if you know what I mean?"

"So no aching knees and graying hair?" Catra teases. "No need for me to send you to a retirement home yet?"

"Nah," Adora says with a lazy grin. "I think I'm good."

Catra smiles and rests her head against Adora's shoulder. They're sitting on Catra's bed with their backs against the wall, their bare feet dangling over the edge. Halloween is only a few days away, and Catra has gone all out with the mood lighting, draping fairy lights over mirrors and shelves and curtain rods. It's dark outside, but there's a soft glow in the room, a hazy purple hue, shadows lurking in the corners. Soft music flows through the speakers, one of those lesbian indie artists Adora likes to listen to. It's a perfect little bubble they have built for themselves, and Catra doesn't want it to ever burst.

"You seriously don't want to do anything special for your birthday?" Adora asks.

"You already threw me a party last week, Adora." It had been a small get-together with a few close friends, and they had fun, but Catra likes this more, just hanging out with Adora in the safe cocoon of her bedroom, listening to music and making out and talking about nothing in particular for hours and hours and hours.

"Yeah, but today's your twentieth birthday," Adora says. "I mean, it's kind of a big deal."

Catra hums in agreement. Adora's not wrong. In Etheria, you become an adult when you turn twenty; it's a rite of passage, one of the big milestones in your life. It's when proud parents throw huge parties for their kids and shower them with lavish gifts, anything from cars to jewelry. Catra's mom never gave a shit about her, and she has never even met her dad, let alone received a birthday card or a gift from him. Sometimes, it really hurts, a physical ache in her chest that doesn't seem to want to go away, but tonight, she's more than happy to be here in her tiny one-bedroom apartment with Adora, tucked away from the cold and the rain. She's by far the most important person in Catra's life, and the only one who truly matters.

"All I want is to get the fuck out of this city, but that's not really an option," she says. There's nothing wrong about Bright Moon per se, but it has never felt like home to her, possibly because of the bad memories she associates with the place.

"Yeah, but we'll be done with college in a couple of years, and then we can do whatever we want."

"I don't want to wait for a couple of years," Catra mutters. "I want to get out of here *right now.*"

Adora looks thoughtful. "I mean, we could do something over Christmas break. Go away for a couple of days, something like that."

Something lights up inside of Catra, like a match bursting into flame. She scrambles to her knees and turns to look at Adora,

barely able to contain herself.

“We could go away tomorrow,” she says, grabbing Adora’s wrist.

Adora blinks at her, clearly not comprehending this. “What?”

“Just for a few days,” Catra says quickly. “I don’t want to spend my birthday week in Bright Moon. It would be the lamest thing ever.”

Adora looks conflicted, her forehead scrunching up in confusion. “Catra, we can’t--”

“You asked me if there was anything special I wanted to do for my birthday,” Catra says. “This is it. I want to go traveling with you. I don’t even care where we go. I just want to see new places, experience new things. I just want to -- live.”

She lets go of Adora’s wrist, waits for her to speak. Adora doesn’t say anything. She has that shine in her eyes that tells Catra she’s definitely *interested*, but something’s holding her back. She has an unfortunate tendency to make decisions based on what parents, professors, and other authority figures expect from her, which often leads to her lighting herself on fire to keep others warm. Catra has been trying to encourage her to follow her own path, but Adora still tends to put others first without a second thought, completely ignoring herself in the process. Catra can’t blame her; Adora has been conditioned to think this way, the only child to a mother who was always determined to control all aspects of her own life, including that of her daughter’s. It must have been a tough environment to grow up in, and Adora still carries those younger versions of herself inside her, all these years later.

“We can’t just leave,” Adora says. “We have classes next week. Responsibilities, things to take care of.”

“We can skip a few days of classes. Most of them don’t even require attendance.”

“But our essays--”

"We submit them online anyway, Adora. You don't have to be physically here to do it."

"I guess I could take my laptop with me," Adora says, a hesitant edge to her voice. "But how would we even do this, Catra? We don't have a lot of money. Neither of us has a car, and public transport sucks around here."

"We could hitchhike," Catra says, the idea popping into her mind as she speaks it. The thought makes her so excited that she has to fight the urge to jump to her feet. "It's by far the most affordable way to travel, *and* we'd even meet new people."

Adora quirks an eyebrow at her. She still hasn't said no, which is a good thing. She doesn't *look* like she wants to say no. Adora is an adventurer at heart, someone who thrives in the face of the unknown. As a kid, her biggest dream was to be an astronaut; when they were fifteen, they would sneak out at night and ride their bikes all around town, exploring creepy abandoned places and venturing out into the nearby woods. That fun-loving girl is still somewhere inside her, and all she has to do is allow that part of her to come out.

"It's not that I don't want to," Adora says.

"I know." Catra settles down on the bed, cross-legged, eyes never leaving Adora's. "Think about it this way. There will never be a better time for spontaneous travel. We won't be able to just pack our bags and leave when we have jobs and stuff. This is the most freedom we'll ever have as adults, and we should make the most of it while it lasts."

A slow smile blooms on Adora's face. "You know, I've always wondered what it would be like to just jump in a car and go somewhere far away. No plans, no maps, nothing. Just endless freedom."

"Me too." Catra takes Adora's hand, holding it between her own. "Adora, do you want to go on a hitchhiking trip with me?"

Adora's smile is wide now, genuine and precious. "I do."

Catra cups Adora's head in her hands and kisses her right on the lips, unable to contain her joy.

"Wait," she says, murmuring this against Adora's mouth. "Am I pressuring you? You can still say no. It's okay if you say no."

Adora laughs and captures Catra's lips with her own, her free hand warm and steady on the back of Catra's neck. There is no hesitation in the kiss. There is no tension in Adora's muscles either, her body pliant against Catra's, a comforting presence. She tends to be tense when she's overthinking, unable to relax. There's no sign of it now, which is a relief.

"Go pack your stuff," Adora says when their mouths separate. "We're leaving first thing tomorrow."

Catra practically bounces off the bed. She doesn't need to be told twice.

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The next morning, they find themselves on the side of the road leading out of town, bleary-eyed but excited. It's way too early to be awake. The sun peeks out from behind the horizon, and the world is still and silent, save for the occasional roar of a passing car. Catra shivers under her jacket and shoves her hands into her pockets, wishing she'd brought her gloves. She'd packed haphazardly, stuffing random pieces of clothing into her backpack, along with a few other essentials, chargers and toiletries. There's nothing planned about any of this, and it's exhilarating and nerve-racking all at once, exactly what an adventure should be.

Adora glances over at her, hands resting on the straps of her backpack. She'd gone home last night to get extra clothes for the trip, sneaking back into Catra's apartment well after midnight. The fact that they're awake at this hour is nothing short of a miracle.

"How are we supposed to do this?" she asks.

“I guess you’ll have to hold your arm out with your thumb up, just like in movies,” Catra says.

“Right.” Adora rubs the back of her neck, ponytail swinging slightly in the wind. “What if we get picked up by a bunch of cannibals or something?”

“I’ll kick their asses,” Catra says with an air of confidence, a smile tugging at the corners of her lips when Adora barks out a laugh. The idea is ridiculous, because she’s smaller and not as strong as Adora, but she would do anything to protect her, even if it meant fighting a horde of cannibals with her bare hands.

“Okay,” Adora says. “Here we go. You ready?”

“Yeah,” Catra says, and extends her arm, just like she has always wanted to do.

The first car that pulls over is an electric blue Honda Civic. It’s occupied by two people, a broad-shouldered man with a moustache and a woman with a long, thick braid. She sits behind the wheel, and he peers at them through the windshield, an openly curious expression on his face.

“Morning,” Adora says as the guy rolls down the passenger side window, sticking his head and elbow out. “Where are you headed?”

“Salineas!” the guy says, a proud ring in his voice. “How about you, ladies?”

Adora looks over to Catra. “We could do Salineas, right?”

Catra has never been to Salineas, but she has heard a lot of things about it. She has heard about the swaying palm trees and the sparkling blue-green ocean, the endlessly long white-sand beaches. Compared to the chaotic concrete jungle that is Bright Moon, it sounds like a paradise.

“Sure,” Catra says. “What do you think, Adora?”

"I'd *love* to go to Salineas." Adora turns back to the guy and leans a little closer to him, her voice almost drowned out by the rumble of passing cars. "Do you happen to have room for two hitchhikers? We're freshly showered and well-behaved, and we can treat you to lunch at a place of your choice."

"Yeah, sure," the woman says immediately, something that surprises Catra. She had thought they'd have to stand on the side of the road for hours and spend a lot of time trying to persuade drivers to pick them up. "C'mon, get in."

Adora and Catra climb into the backseat, and then they're off, the road an endless stretch ahead of them, the engine rumbling under them.

Adora hits it off with the couple right away. They introduce themselves as Sea Hawk and Mermista, two native Salineans heading home after a few days in Bright Moon.

"A family reunion," Sea Hawk explains. "And why are the two of you hitching a ride out of town early in the morning, if I may ask?"

Adora glances over at Catra, a smile on her face. "It was my girlfriend's idea. She wanted to go on a trip for her twentieth birthday."

"Oh, perfect!" Sea Hawk lights up like a Christmas tree; Catra can see his eyes shining in the rear-view mirror. "There's never a bad time for adventure. I am something of an adventurer myself, a sailor of the seven seas."

"No, you're not," Mermista says in a tone that suggests they've had this conversation before. She looks at Adora and Catra through the mirror, lips twitching. "He works on rich people's yachts docked in the Salineas harbor. This is the longest he's been away from home in, like, three years."

"Why must you always do this to me, dearest?" Sea Hawk asks, pretending to be wounded by this. "We all know that at the end of

the day, adventure is a state of mind rather than a specific activity."

He has a funny way of saying adventure, the last syllable drawn out, his tone changing slightly every time he speaks the word. Catra makes eye contact with Adora, and as soon as she sees the expression on her face, she knows that Adora is thinking the same thing. Catra turns her head away quickly, working hard to keep her expression neutral.

"Yeah, sure, babe." Mermista's face melts into a tender smile, a smile reserved only for him. "You miss home, don't you?"

"Terribly," Sea Hawk admits without hesitation. "Now, let me at least listen to something that reminds me of it."

He fiddles with the radio until a chorus of male voices fills the car, a little too loud in the quiet of the morning. It's not the kind of music Catra typically listens to, the song silly and old-fashioned, sung without instrumental accompaniment. She doesn't particularly like it either, but Sea Hawk's knee is already bouncing to the beat, his lips moving along to the lyrics.

"Not now, honey," Mermista says, hissing this. "We've got *company*."

Sea Hawk holds up a hand. "Dearest, I must do this. What better way to introduce the girls to Salinean culture than with a shanty? Besides, it makes any journey a hundred times more enjoyable."

He turns up the volume and starts singing, his voice booming through the car. He's off-key and off-tempo, but what he lacks in skill, he makes up for in enthusiasm, his rendition hilariously over the top, like a bad musical number.

"Oh my God," Mermista says in a comically flat tone. She facepalms with one hand, the other still safely on the wheel, but Catra can see that she's smiling, the corner of her mouth curled up. Catra looks down at her lap and tries not to burst out

laughing, but it's almost impossible, happiness bubbling up inside her chest like champagne.

Adora perks up. "I know this song. My ex-roommate was raised in Salineas, and she used to sing it all the time."

She starts humming along with the tune, head bobbing slightly to the beat. There's a smile on her face and a spark in her eye and Catra can't stop staring at her. Her heart blooms like a flower, petals turned to the sun that is Adora's face. She feels warm and flushed and enchanted, and the feeling only intensifies when Adora bursts into song too, belting out the lyrics as loud as she can.

"*Adora.*" Catra wants it to sound like a warning, but it comes out as a breathless half-laugh.

"What?" Adora asks, glancing at her. "Come on, Catra. Join us! This is fun!"

Catra lets out a half-hearted scoff. Singing is not fun. Catra does not sing, not when she's alone and certainly not when she's with other people. She hates the idea of making a fool of herself. Then again, Sea Hawk and Adora are currently making fools of themselves, and they don't seem to care. In fact, they're the ones having the most fun, and isn't that kind of the whole point? They're on this trip to have fun, to experience new things. What is she going to get out of it if she never says yes to anything?

Oh, fuck it, Catra thinks. And then, in some momentary lapse of rationality, she opens her mouth, singing the strangely familiar lyrics. It's not easy, and she's no better at it than Sea Hawk, but she's also kind of laughing her way through the lyrics, enjoying the shared experience more than the actual act of singing. It's a little embarrassing too, but also oddly freeing, like opening a gate to a new world, and she would be lying if she said she wasn't the least bit curious to find out what it has in store for her.

“What the hell, you guys,” Mermista says, her voice almost drowned out by their singing. “You are so lame.” But then she starts singing too, and somehow, she’s the best singer out of all of them, her voice clear and powerful and melodious.

The song goes on and on, but they don’t stop, their voices a cacophony of chaos and joy. The people in passing cars probably look at them like they’ve lost their minds, but they don’t care. They’re driving straight into the sunrise, and there’s the first hint of ocean in the air, and it’s already getting easier to breathe.

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They spend two days on the beach, alternating between soaking up the sun and lounging in the shade, under one of the many brightly-colored beach umbrellas dotting the shoreline. Catra stays well away from the water and looks on as Adora frolics in the waves, clearly enjoying herself. Amidst the blue waters, she’s a splash of color, her bright red swimsuit eye-catching, her smile as bright as the sun. Catra adjusts the sunglasses on her face and hides her own smile behind a can of soda.

“Can I ask you something?” Adora says as they’re walking along the beach on their last night in Salineas, their hands laced together. It’s dark now, the sky and the ocean the same shade of deep blue, the soft glow of the moons the only light to be seen. The crowds have disappeared; the beach umbrellas have been folded up for the night. If Catra turned to face the ocean, she could pretend to be the only person in the world.

Catra glances over at Adora. “Yeah?”

“Why don’t you like being in the water?” Adora asks. “I mean, I’ve always known you hate it, but is there a specific story behind it or something?”

“There’s not,” Catra says. “I just don’t like the feel of it on my skin. It’s cold and slippery and disgusting. Ugh, just thinking about it makes me shudder.”

“Right,” Adora says. Catra doesn’t expect her to understand. Adora was always one of the better swimmers in their class, someone who felt at home in the water, while Catra couldn’t even stay afloat without flailing around like an idiot.

Catra turns her head away. “I know it’s weird. I don’t mind looking at the ocean. I just don’t want to go anywhere near it.”

“I don’t think there’s anything weird about it,” Adora says. “People hate different things. For you, it’s water, and for me, it’s, I don’t know, cooking? Just because someone likes what you don’t like, it doesn’t mean you’re wrong for disliking it.”

Catra hums in agreement, lets her shoulders drop. She still remembers how her elementary school gym teacher made fun of her when she refused to go swimming, her classmates staring at her with amused interest as she stood by the pool, head hanging in shame. She’s glad those people aren’t in her life anymore.

Adora squeezes her hand, and she squeezes back, comforted by its warmth. The waves roll onto the shore in a gentle, unhurried rhythm, the foamy crests lit by the moonlight.

“Remember all those days we spent on the beach when we were kids?” Adora asks.

“Oh, yeah, the legendary Bright Moon Beach. How could I ever forget.”

“I used to piggyback you everywhere. You loved every moment of it.”

“I did not!” Catra did like it, actually; she couldn’t explain it at the time, but there was something about wrapping her arms around Adora’s shoulders and pressing her stomach against her back that made her feel happy and tingly. Looking back, it was one of the earliest signs that what she felt for Adora was more than just friendship.

“How about I give you a piggyback ride right now?” The corner of Adora’s mouth quirks into a playful smile. “Just for old times’ sake.”

“No. Absolutely not.” It doesn’t come out as convincing as Catra hoped it would.

“C’mon, Catra.” Adora stops and turns to face away from her, motioning her to get on her back. “This place is practically empty.”

Catra folds her arms on her chest. “No.”

“Why not? What’s the worst thing that could happen?”

“Um, losing the respect of everyone who happens to see us?”

“So what? We don’t even know these people. No one here knows us, Catra.”

Catra opens her mouth for a retort, only to realize she doesn’t know what to say. As much as she hates to admit it, Adora *does* have a point. And then there’s the fact that a small part of her misses it, the feeling of being lifted off the ground, the tickle of Adora’s hair on her face, the flicker of *something* in her chest--

“God, you’re such a dork.” Catra glances around before stepping closer and grabbing Adora’s shoulders. Adora hoists her up with ease, hooking her arms under Catra’s thighs, and yes, it still feels exactly like Catra remembers.

“Oh, wow,” Adora says. “You’re as light as I remember.”

Catra snorts. “I weigh much more than I did when I was eight, Adora. You’ve just gotten stronger.”

“I mean, I *have* been lifting a lot of weights recently,” Adora says, her voice taking on a smug note.

Catra slaps her on the shoulder. “Show-off.”

“You know what?” Adora says. “Forget hitchhiking. This is the superior way to travel. I could take you anywhere, seriously.”

“No,” Catra says. She knows Adora can hear the smile in her voice. “Don’t even *think* about it. This is embarrassing enough. I--”

She forgets what she’s about to say, because suddenly, Adora takes off, running along the shore, hair whipping against Catra’s face. Catra shrieks with laughter and holds on to her tight, heart fluttering in delight.

“Stop!” They’re breathless and probably a little too loud, but there’s practically no one else around, and they don’t care. “Stop or I’ll -- I’ll--”

She wraps herself around Adora like a monkey and forces her weight on her, trying to push her down. She doesn’t know if it works or if Adora’s just laughing too hard to keep running, but after a brief struggle, she sinks to her knees in the sand, head tipped down, shoulders still shaking from laughter. Catra lets go of her and flops down on the ground, giggling uncontrollably. The fresh ocean air feels good in her lungs, a cleansing for the soul. She wishes she could bottle it up and take it home with her.

Adora turns around to look at her, still smiling. Her hair is a mess, strands coming loose from her ponytail, a broken halo around her head; her eyes dance like the stars in the black-blue sky above them. A moment of stillness, and then she crawls on top of Catra and leans down to kiss her, all soft lips and warm breath and teasing tongue. Catra wraps her arms around Adora’s neck and loses herself in the kiss. There’s sand everywhere, in her hair and under her shirt and between her toes. Somewhere in the background, the ocean heaves and sighs, a steady, soothing sound. There’s an inexplicable lightness in Catra’s body and heart, but at the same time, she knows the force of her love could move mountains.

Chapter 2

The following day, they wake up early and make the one-mile trek to the highway, ready to hitch a ride out of town. They don't know what their next destination will be, but what they do know is that they're not ready to go back home yet. Catra's just got her first taste of freedom, and she's hungry for more, her appetite growing stronger with each passing moment.

This time, they're picked up by two women who introduce themselves as Spinnerella and Netossa.

"Where are you headed?" Netossa asks through the open window of the car.

Catra adjusts the backpack on her shoulders. "Wherever you are."

Netossa flashes them a grin. "Ooh, I like that attitude. How does Mystacor sound?"

Catra looks over at Adora.

"Mystacor it is, then," Adora says, smiling, and puts her hand on the car door.

Spinnerella and Netossa are a little older than Catra and Adora, somewhere in their thirties, but Catra immediately feels at home in their company, like she's hanging out with family members she hasn't seen in a while. The two women don't elaborate on their relationship right away, but Catra doesn't miss the way Spinnerella puts her hand on Netossa's thigh as she turns around to make sure Catra and Adora have made themselves comfortable in the backseat, or the way Netossa's hand brushes against Spinnerella's as she puts the car into gear. They wear rings that look suspiciously like wedding rings, and Catra shouldn't be jumping into conclusions, but her heart's already swelling with hope, and there's nothing she can do to stop it.

At first, they don't talk much, all four of them still tired, blinking against the early morning sun. Catra turns her head idly to the side, casts a fond look at Adora. She hasn't been able to take her eyes off her all morning. Maybe it's the exhilaration of being away from home with her, the thrill of traveling. Maybe it's the fact that she's had Adora to herself for two whole days. Either way, Catra is acutely aware of her presence, the sleepy warmth of her body next to her own, the comforting familiarity of her.

She reaches out for her, takes Adora's hand in hers. Adora glances up at her, eyebrows raised, then smiles, stroking her thumb over Catra's.

Spinnerella's eyes flicker to them in the rear-view mirror, her expression softening.

"How sweet," she says, her face melting into a gentle smile. "We used to be like that too, Netossa. Remember?"

Netossa swats Spinnerella on the arm. "You make it sound like we're ancient. We're not that old!"

"How long have you two been together?" Spinnerella asks them.

"Almost a year, but we've been best friends since we learned to walk," Catra says.

"Ah," Spinnerella says. "Me and Netossa were friends at first, too. How old were we when we started dating? Eighteen, nineteen? Gosh, it's been almost fifteen years."

"Which means our ten-year wedding anniversary is coming up soon," Netossa says.

Spinnerella shakes her head. "I can't believe it."

"I can." Netossa smirks, eyes not leaving the road. "Married life is pretty sweet. You guys should definitely consider it, if marriage's your thing."

She says it in a joking tone, but it's still enough to knock the air out of Catra's lungs, her thoughts scattering like marbles on a hardwood floor. Adora just looks out the window and smiles, her hand firm in Catra's own.

"Netossa!" Spinnerella whacks her playfully on the shoulder. "You can't say things like that! The girls have just started dating. You'll scare the poor things off."

"Just kidding." Netossa glances at them through the mirror, her smirk fading into something softer and more genuine. "If it's too early to think about marriage, traveling together is the next best thing."

Adora perks up at this. "Do you two travel a lot?"

"We always have," Spinnerella says. "It's one of my favorite things to do with her. It might not always be smooth sailing, but you'll make memories together that will last a lifetime. There's nothing better than sharing those experiences with someone you love. You're not only nurturing yourself, but your love for each other, too."

Catra sinks deeper into the seat, her chest blooming with warmth. This is exactly what she wants to do. She wants to travel with Adora, wants to travel to places they haven't even heard of before. She wants to see the sparkle in Adora's eyes, the smile on her lips. If there was one thing she could give Adora in life, it would be this, and the fact that they're on the road *right now* makes her so happy that she feels like she could float away.

"I like that," Adora says.

She's silent for a long time afterwards, staring out the window, lost in thought. Catra looks at her out of the corner of her eye, drinking in the sight of her. Outside, the shoreline gives way to a patchwork of open fields, a thick line of trees visible in the distance. Catra lets her head fall back against the headrest and closes her eyes, hand still in Adora's.

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Catra growls at the laptop screen in front of her, glaring at the innocently blinking cursor at the end of her unfinished sentence. “This is pointless. Remind me why we are doing this again, Adora?”

Adora looks up from her own laptop, blinking. “Um, because we want to graduate and become productive members of society?”

Catra makes a face. “I’m seriously starting to question my life decisions. This is a total waste of time.”

There’s a ghost of a smirk playing on Adora’s lips. “Are you telling me you’d rather go out and explore Mystacor instead of staying cooped up in this Airbnb and working on our essays?”

Catra rolls her eyes at her. “Oh, please. I’ve written two hundred words in the last two hours.”

Adora leans back in her chair and raises her arms above her head in a long stretch. She’s sprawled out on the armchair in the corner of the room, her laptop balanced precariously on her knees, while Catra sits hunched over the only desk in the room, shoulders tense.

“Maybe we should just call it a day,” Adora says.

“That’s the best thing I’ve heard all day.” Catra saves the document and claps the laptop shut, a wave of relief spilling over her. “I can’t believe we were planning on spending the day catching up on homework. It’s Halloween night, Adora, and we’re in Mystacor. We should do something fun.”

“Speaking of which,” Adora says, lifting the laptop from her lap and setting it down on the table beside her. “There’s this place we could check out.”

This lifts Catra’s spirits immediately. “Something Halloween-related?”

“Yeah. It’s not too far from here. A thirty-minute walk, maybe.”

Catra is already on her feet, looking for her shoes. “What are we waiting for? Show me the way.”

They make their way to the outskirts of town, walking through residential neighborhoods and practically tiptoeing past quiet little parks, marveling at the Halloween decorations people have put up on their front lawns. It’s the perfect Halloween night, the world dark and muted, a wispy cloud drifting past a cluster of moons. Catra is having too much fun to think about what is waiting for them; it’s not until they turn off onto a dirt road and head deeper into the woods that she gets butterflies in her stomach. It’s a good kind of excitement, a mixture of nerves and anticipation. She doesn’t think she’ll ever be too old for an adventure like this, especially if Adora’s there with her.

After a few more minutes of walking, they arrive at their destination. It’s an old house that looks like no one has lived there for years, weather-worn and derelict. Some of the windows are broken, and the roof over the front porch looks like it could collapse at any moment. It’s surrounded by a dense garden, the grass overgrown and unkempt, the slender branches of the trees drooping like those of the weeping willow. In the quiet stillness of the night, the house looks eerie and ominous, like the set of a horror movie. It’s something they would have lost their minds over when they were fifteen, and it still sends a shiver of thrill down Catra’s spine.

“What is this place?” she asks.

“A haunted house,” Adora says. “Well, it’s supposed to be haunted, at least. I looked it up online.”

“And here I was thinking you were working on your essay,” Catra teases.

Adora gives her a sheepish smile. “I might have taken a break at some point.”

“So, what’s the story?”

“According to this blog post I found, the house was once inhabited by an old woman, but she died several decades ago, and the house has been abandoned ever since. One day, a little girl who lived nearby snuck out of her bedroom to explore the house. And, well, she never came back home. Her shoes were found on the front porch, but the body was nowhere to be seen. The locals involved in the search reported seeing thin smoke curling out of the chimney, which was weird, because the house was completely empty and the fireplace hadn’t been lit in years. Something creepy was going on, so they just left the house to rot and never looked back.”

Catra laughs at this, nearly doubling over, tears tickling at the corners of her eyes. “God, that is *so* unoriginal. Even I could come up with a better story.”

“I guess it’s a little, um, uninspired,” Adora says, smiling.

Despite everything, Catra is intrigued. She’s making her way closer before she even fully realizes it, drawn to the mysterious house like a magnet to iron. Haunted or not, the house has a story to tell, and Catra is all ears.

She stops, glances over her shoulder. Adora hasn’t moved an inch. She stares at the house, deep in thought, everything else forgotten. Catra waits for a moment, but nothing happens.

“You coming?” she asks.

Adora blinks and looks back at her, as if only now remembering where she is. “Oh -- yeah. Of course.”

Someone has left the door ajar, an invitation to enter. Catra pushes it open, and they walk in, careful as always, more worried about the house collapsing on them than encountering malevolent spirits. The floorboards creak dangerously under their feet, groaning with every step. There’s a smell of mold in the air, faint but distinct. Catra narrows her eyes to see better in the near-dark,

but nothing catches her attention, the furniture plain and simple and dirty, the walls stripped bare. It doesn't stop the adrenaline from running through her body, or her heart from beating hard inside her chest, like a countdown to something sinister.

They go back outside and walk around the house, looking for anything that stands out to them. On one side, there's a ladder leading up to the roof. Curiosity gets the better of Catra, and she grabs the ladder and starts climbing, careful not to get splinters from the weather-beaten wood.

"Are you sure that's a good idea?" Adora calls from below.

Catra pauses just long enough to glance down at her. "Don't worry. I'll come back down if the roof's not safe enough."

The roof is covered in moss, dotted with patches of emerald green. It seems surprisingly secure, but Catra decides to play it safe anyway, moving on all fours rather than on two feet. She rolls onto her back and sighs as she looks up to the sky, the moons and the stars closer now, almost within reach.

"Everything okay?" Adora asks, yelling.

"Better than okay. Why are you still down there?"

She hears a creak, followed by the soft sound of shoes on wood. A moment later, Adora's head pops over the edge of the roof. She crawls over to Catra and sits down beside her, leaning back on her arms.

"So," Catra says, conversational. "The sky looks nice from here."

Adora doesn't say anything. She stares at Catra, distracted, her face blank and unreadable.

Catra is starting to feel slightly uncomfortable. "Why are you looking at me like that?"

Adora sighs, shakes her head. “It’s just -- how do you do it? How are you always so fearless?”

“What?” Catra blinks, dumbfounded. She has never thought of herself as particularly fearless. She certainly didn’t feel fearless when she was hiding her feelings from Adora, or when she finally confessed how she felt, her heart pounding so fast that she thought it would burst out of her chest. “What the hell are you talking about?”

“Well, you just walked into a creepy old house without a second thought.”

This makes Catra, if possible, even more confused. “You’re the one who brought me here, Adora. If I am fearless, then what are *you*?”

Adora shakes her head. “You know, I thought being here would make me feel like a kid again. I guess it does, to some extent, but now I have this voice in my head. It keeps saying things like, *this is a waste of time*, or, *stop goofing around, act your age, and focus on things that actually matter*. Do you ever have thoughts like that?”

Catra doesn’t even have to think about the answer. “Not really.”

“See?” Adora sighs again; it’s a world-weary sigh, something that shouldn’t come from someone as young as her. “Nothing ever holds you back. You don’t let your worries control you. You don’t let other people control you. If you want to do something, you just do it. You have this -- confidence, this fearlessness. It’s one of the things I love about you.”

Catra contemplates this, eyes lingering on the stars. Maybe there’s a seed of truth in what Adora says. There was always a fundamental difference between the two of them, and it was that people cared about Adora too much while no one cared about Catra at all.

Catra wasn't loved by her mother. She never did well in school; even the teachers tended to ignore her. She remembers being eight years old and thinking of herself as a waste of space, something that breaks her heart now, twelve years later. It instilled a sense of otherness in her, a feeling of not being part of anything, of not mattering. It's easy to live your life without fear when you have nothing to lose, no one to disappoint. Meanwhile, Adora grew up with parents and teachers constantly telling her how talented and special she was, everyone around her always reminding her that she was destined for greatness. No wonder she grew up to be an anxious adult, overwhelmed by the fear of imperfection.

"I don't think worrying is necessarily a bad thing," Catra says finally. "It's an indicator of what is important to you. But are those worries really your own, or did someone else plant them in your head?"

"I don't know." Adora's voice is so small, so fragile, that Catra has to fight the urge to pull her into her arms and just hold her. She swallows heavily instead, waits for Adora to continue. "I mean, I *want* to graduate with a good GPA. I *want* to get a good job that also makes me happy. Those things do matter to me."

"Right."

"But sometimes I feel this overwhelming pressure to excel in everything I do. It's like there's this weight pushing me down, and I'll suffocate if I make just one tiny mistake. I don't -- I don't think that thought is entirely mine. The soul-crushing fear definitely isn't."

Catra doesn't need to think hard to figure out who put that thought in Adora's head. It was Adora's mother, the conniving, manipulating, self-obsessed monster of a human being. Adora lives on her own now and has little to no contact with her mother, but she has still managed to worm her way inside Adora's head, and it doesn't look like she'll be able to get rid of her anytime

soon. It's a vicious battle, and Catra wants to help Adora any way she can.

"But you also wanted to show me this place," Catra says. "That's the Adora I know, the one that has always been drawn to adventure and mystery."

"That does sound more like me." Adora's face eases into a small smile, some of the tension in her body melting away. "I'm glad that version of me still exists."

"You haven't lost her," Catra says. "You're growing up. Your priorities are changing, which is not a bad thing. It's just what happens when you're dealing with new responsibilities and obligations. I just -- please promise me you won't forget who you are. The real Adora is -- is too precious to be lost."

"I promise." Adora looks at Catra, her eyes taking on a fond glow. "Being with you makes it easier. I think it's because you know me better than anyone else. I never have to pretend when I'm with you, and--"

Suddenly, Adora freezes, the smile disappearing from her face. She sits up straighter, glancing around wildly. "Did you hear that?"

"What?" Catra sits up, listening carefully. Now she can hear it too, this low hissing sound emanating from inside the house, slightly muffled but clearly audible. "What the hell is that? Did someone enter the house?"

"It doesn't sound like it comes from a human being."

"No." Catra swallows; her throat is uncomfortably dry. "It really doesn't."

She can hear it more clearly now, as if whatever's down there is making its way closer. It almost sounds like whispering, except it's louder and sharper and more ominous than anything Catra has ever heard before. A chill runs down her spine, making her shiver.

She turns her head just in time to see something curling out of the chimney. It's thinner than smoke, almost translucent, and instead of drifting up into the sky, it twists in the air, tendrils reaching out for them like the long, slender fingers of a bony hand--

"Run!"

Catra's not sure whether it's her or Adora who shouts it first, but they leap into action at the same time, scrambling towards the ladder, shoes slipping on the mossy tiles. Catra gets there first, swinging herself onto it and climbing down as fast as humanly possible. Adora's right behind her, her breath coming in erratic bursts. Catra's heart is beating so hard that it feels like it's trying to hammer its way out of her chest.

"Come on, Adora!" Catra takes Adora's hand as soon as Adora's feet touch the ground and pulls her along, running away from the house. All she can hear is the crunch of their shoes on the gravel, her own ragged gasps. Adora squeezes her hand like she never wants to let go.

Catra looks back at the house over her shoulder. The windows are still dark; there is no sign of people anywhere, no fire or flames or anything that could explain the smoke, nothing. Catra turns her head back to the road in front of them and runs and runs and runs, lungs burning and ribs aching. Her heart's in her throat, and fear swirls around in her stomach, but it's not entirely unpleasant, the initial shock turning into an almost giddy sense of relief as they leave the house behind.

She doesn't know how long they run, but eventually they stop, both of them doubling over with hands on their knees, gasping for air. They're shaky and exhausted but also laughing under their breaths, thrilled by the whole thing. Adora stands up straighter and pushes stray hairs away from her sweaty forehead, chest heaving.

"Seriously, what the hell was that?" she asks.

Catra sucks in a deep breath. “No idea. A trick of the mind, maybe.”

“Yeah, or, I don’t know. Some kind of illusion?”

“I don’t want to think about what it was.” Catra raises her head, looks up at the road in front of her. In the distance, the lights of Mystacor twinkle against the night sky, bright and comforting. “Come on, Adora. Let’s go back to the Airbnb.”

She holds out her hand for Adora, and together, they make their way back to town, not once letting go of each other’s hands.

Chapter 3

The woman who picks them up is on her way to Plumeria. She's friendly but visibly nervous, fidgeting with her hands as Catra and Adora climb into the backseat, eyes flicking around in an almost panicked way. Catra's first thought is that she's on the run from something, but she pushes it aside, not wanting to make herself worry. There's not much traffic out this morning, and who knows how long they will have to wait until someone else offers them a ride?

"Ready to go?" the woman asks, almost knocking over a bottle of water as she turns around in her seat to look at them. "Oh -- oops!"

She fumbles with the bottle for a moment before setting it back in the cup holder. She has a large tuft of silver hair on her head; her hands are big and plump, soft-looking. Catra stares at them as the woman turns the key in the ignition and puts one hand on the steering wheel and the other on the gear shift, steering the car back on the road.

Adora and Catra exchange a quick, meaningful look. This is not ideal, but it'll have to do.

"Everything okay?" Adora asks carefully after a moment of awkward silence.

The woman jumps a little, sitting up straighter.

"What? Oh, yes, yes, everything's great." She lets out a tight laugh; it doesn't sound particularly convincing. "It's just that I, um. I'm kind of on a mission here, and I would be lying if I said I wasn't just a little bit nervous about it."

Oh, really? Catra wants to say, voice filled with sarcasm. Instead, she bites the inside of her cheek and lets Adora do the talking.

"What kind of mission, if you don't mind me asking?" Adora says.

The woman is silent for a moment, the set of her shoulders tense, her knuckles white around the steering wheel.

"Well, there's this girl," she says, speaking carefully, as if weighing the words on her tongue.

"Oh," Adora says, realization dawning on her. "Hey, we've all been there. I don't know the exact details of your situation, but I'm sure it's going to be okay."

"I really hope so." The woman sighs, shaking her head a little. "I met her in Plumeria a few months ago. I liked her from the moment I first set eyes on her, but I was too scared to say anything. We got along really well, and I was pretty sure she liked me back, but I -- I kept doubting myself. Whenever I was alone, I had all these thoughts popping into my head. What if I was just imagining things? What if she just liked me as a friend? Why would she even like someone like me in the first place? It was awful."

Oddly enough, this is something Catra can relate to. A year and a half ago, she spent her nights tossing and turning in bed, agonizing over her feelings for Adora, convinced Adora would never see her as anything more than a friend. It didn't help that they'd had a falling out a couple of years before, their friendship almost damaged beyond repair. She should have been grateful they were back to being friends, and to a certain extent she was, but it wasn't enough. She was already falling in love with Adora, and once she was in the freefall, there was no way of stopping it.

"Many people doubt their feelings when they like someone, especially if they start out as being friends," Catra says. "You're -- you're definitely not alone in this."

Adora glances over at her, face like an open book; the regret in her eyes makes Catra's chest ache. They played the she-doesn't-like-me-that-way game for too long, torturing themselves with self-deprecating thoughts, bottling up their emotions. Catra was the more self-aware and self-critical one, while Adora couldn't

quite put her feelings into words, pushing them aside and focusing on making others happy. Had Catra known they were both losing the game, she would have told Adora how she felt a lot sooner.

The woman looks pensive. “I guess you’re right. It’s kind of depressing, though. I don’t want people to suffer. I just want everyone to be happy, if you know what I mean?”

Catra hesitates, looks out the window. She’s not ready to meet the woman’s eyes, not even through the mirror. “It’s part of life. You can’t just stop yourself from feeling things.”

“Sometimes I really wish I could.” The woman shakes her head, a small movement. “Anyway, we had an amazing time together, and I was planning on staying in Plumeria for two more weeks, but then I just kind of -- bailed. I left without explaining why I had to leave. I was lying awake in bed one night, and I had this horrible feeling come over me, and I thought, *she’s never going to like me the way I like her*. It was -- it was too much, so I just got up and packed my bags and walked straight out to my car.”

“Ouch.” Adora makes a face. “That was -- not ideal.”

“I know.” The woman heaves another sigh, staring forlornly at the road ahead. “It’s been a few weeks now. We’ve been texting on and off, and we’re still on pretty good terms with each other, but it’s obvious things have changed between us. We haven’t really talked about the night I left, but I know I let her down when I -- yeah.”

“So now you’re going back to fix things with her?” Catra asks.

“Well, uh -- yeah, that’s the plan.” The woman glances at her through the rear-view mirror before turning her eyes back to the road. “I’m worried it’s too late for me to do anything about it. I mean, I messed up big time. What if she won’t give me a second chance?”

She's starting to fret again, her leg twitching nervously, her grip on the steering wheel tightening. Adora shifts in her seat, and for a moment, she looks like she wants to put her hand on the woman's shoulder. She doesn't, which is probably for the best; at this point, any sudden movement would probably set the woman off.

"Well, none of us knows for sure how things will turn out between the two of you," Adora says after a moment of heavy silence. "I don't even know you, but judging by what you just told us, it's clear that you're someone who really cares about people. And even though you made a mistake, you're owning up to it and willing to work on fixing things. That in itself takes a ton of courage."

A ghost of a smile flickers across the woman's face. "You really think so?"

"Absolutely," Adora says. "And this girl -- well, I don't know her either, but she seems sweet, too. I think she'll give you a second chance, if you just take the time to explain yourself."

The woman's expression softens, her eyes taking on a wistful, faraway look. "She *is* understanding and open-hearted."

"See?" Adora says. "All you have to do is be completely honest with her. I know it's easier said than done, but you're dancing around the issue right now, and talking about your feelings is the only way to fix the relationship between you two. No matter what happens, at least you can say you did all you could, and you won't have any regrets."

The woman lets out an exhale and sits up a little straighter. She's no longer clutching the steering wheel like her life depends on it.

"I think you're right."

Adora's relief is apparent in her eyes. "It's scary, but it'll be worth it in the end. I promise."

The woman nods. “Thanks. I feel a little better now.”

“Hey, you’re giving us a free ride,” Adora says. “This is the least we can do.”

“Nothing like a good, reassuring pep talk in the middle of nowhere, huh?” The woman smiles, almost timid now. “I don’t think I have even introduced myself yet. I’m Scorpia.”

“I’m Adora, and this is Catra,” Adora says.

“Well, nice to meet you both,” Scorpia says. “Where did you say you were from again?”

Catra feels like she should contribute something to the conversation, but her brain refuses to function as it should. She stares at Adora like a fool, trying to make sense of what just happened. This woman was so anxious she could barely drive, and Adora listened to her, understood her, encouraged her. She might not always be perfectly in touch with her own emotions, but she’s always kind to others, always empathetic, always compassionate. If Catra wasn’t already in love with her, she would be falling now, falling and stumbling and plummeting, and she wouldn’t do anything to stop it.

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Plumeria is essentially a city built in a garden, or perhaps a garden that has taken over the city. As soon as Catra climbs out of the car, she’s met by some of the lushest greenery she has ever laid eyes on, a sweeping landscape of tall trees and well-trimmed bushes and pretty flowers. Some of them are in the process of changing color, the leaves a beautiful mixture of vibrant reds, warm oranges and bright yellows. The narrow streets are lined with charming old houses, vines climbing up walls and fences. It’s everything Bright Moon is not, and Catra loves every moment of it.

They spend the day wandering around the city, stumbling into shaded alleyways and charming little parks, spending time in cozy

cafés and cute little boutiques. In the evening, they take a walk along the river that runs through the city. Like the rest of Plumeria, it's a stunningly beautiful place, the water clear and calm, the bridges crossing the river elegant and covered with vines.

There's one bridge in particular that draws Catra's attention, probably because it's filled with people, many of them taking pictures of the bridge itself rather than the river. As soon as she walks onto the bridge, she realizes what they're all looking at; the railings are dotted with padlocks of all colors and sizes, with initials and dates and even short messages carved into them. Catra has never seen love locks before, and her first reaction is to scoff at the sight, to roll her eyes at the cheesiness of the whole concept.

"Seriously, how lame is this?" she says, reaching out for the closest padlock. It's bright pink, the initials L and T written on it in neat cursive.

"I know, right?" Adora says. "It's stupid."

Catra snorts. "So stupid."

"I mean, who even does that? Some hopeless romantic who believes in true love?"

Catra laughs out loud at the way Adora says *true love*, clutching at her sides.

"I bet they're not even together anymore," she says, straightening up.

"*I* bet they wish they could just throw the stupid thing in the river."

They're still snickering at the thought, but there's something disingenuous about it, the laughter not reaching their eyes. The ensuing silence is heavy and not entirely comfortable.

Adora reaches out, takes Catra's hand in hers. "Let's go. I want to treat you to dinner, a really fancy one."

"Adora," Catra says, groaning this in a half-hearted protest. She allows herself to be pulled along anyway, their fingers laced together tightly. "You don't have to--"

"But I want to," Adora says. "Think of it as your official birthday dinner."

Catra huffs. "Okay, but I get to pick the place."

Adora's smile is wide and bright. "Of course. No fast food restaurants, though."

"Fine." Catra has to bite the inside of her cheek to keep from smiling. She's starting to discover that being out of her comfort zone is not such a bad thing, after all.

The dinner is wonderful. They find a nice sit-down restaurant that manages to be intimate and elegant without being tacky or over-the-top romantic. It's a small place with exposed brick walls and mood lighting and pristine white tablecloths, alive with the murmur of conversation and the clinking of cutlery. The food is divine, plant-based and fresh -- some of the main characteristics of the Plumerian cuisine. They drink a little too much wine and even hold hands over the table, talking until Catra's throat is sore. It's different, a good kind of different. Catra knows that becoming an adult doesn't happen overnight, but right here, right now, she does feel a little more mature, a little more like a real grown-up, and it's nowhere near as scary as she had thought.

The sun is setting as they stumble out of the restaurant, the city bathed in a golden glow, the sky a watercolor backdrop of gentle pinks and hazy blues. They're flushed and giggly and a little bit drunk, holding hands as they make their way through the maze of cobble-stoned streets and hidden squares, headed to nowhere in particular. Most of the businesses have already closed for the day, and there's a slight chill in the air, but Catra is not cold. Maybe it's

the wine; maybe it's the warmth of Adora's hand in hers. Either way, she doesn't mind wandering around in a T-shirt a little longer.

All roads in Plumeria seem to lead to the river, because before long, they end up on the bridge again, the one with the love locks attached to the railings. Catra's heart jumps when she sees them, a peculiar combination of amusement and longing. She sneaks a sideways glance at Adora, only to find that she's staring at the padlocks too, lost in thought. Her eyes are heavy-lidded, and her mouth is parted, and Catra would do anything, absolutely anything, to make her happy.

Their eyes meet, and Catra knows immediately what's on Adora's mind. There is no need for words. They've known each other long enough that they can practically read each other's thoughts, communicate through looks and touches. Sometimes, Catra just doesn't feel like talking. Other times, she's not as brave as she likes to make out. But Adora's always there to pick up the signals, to decode the message, to set things in motion, and it makes all the difference.

The little store that sells padlocks is still open. They purchase a plain, silver-colored padlock; it's small and delicate and feels pleasantly cool against Catra's palm, like an amulet or a good luck charm. Adora leans over to write their initials and the date on it, tongue peeking out of the corner of her mouth. Catra can't help but stare at her, her hands and her face and that damned tip of her tongue. *You don't know how much I love you*, she almost blurts out, but the walls are too close and the owner is standing right behind the counter, so she keeps her mouth shut and thinks about kissing Adora instead.

There are not many people around anymore, just a few couples heading back home, holding hands. The sunset has faded into purple-blue twilight, a scatter of stars visible in the sky. They find a good spot near the middle of the bridge, and Catra holds the padlock in place while Adora sets the combination, her fingers turning the tiny little dials, their hands brushing against each

other in the process. They won't remember the combination in the morning. They're not *supposed* to remember the combination in the morning. The padlock will be there for years, maybe even decades, a token of their love for each other. They can come back to Plumeria in thirty, forty, fifty years, smiling fondly at each other as they stand at this exact same spot, murmuring things like, *remember that night?* or *oh, we were so young back then*. The thought fills Catra with a curious sense of longing, an ache that almost brings tears to her eyes.

"You done?" she asks when Adora steps back, examining their work. Here, in the rapidly vanishing daylight, she looks almost reverent, her head tipped forward, arms limp against her sides.

"Yeah." Adora's mouth curls into a soft smile. "It's perfect."

"It's ours." Catra doesn't want to let go of the padlock, doesn't want to let go of this moment. This is what she meant when she told Adora she wanted to live. This thump-thump-thump of her heart, this whirlwind of emotions inside her, this breathlessness of being head over heels in love. These fragments out of time that are larger than life itself. Here they are, fulfilling their dreams one by one.

"Come here," Adora says, voice impossibly soft. Catra allows herself to be pulled away from the railing and into Adora's arms. She puts her hands on Adora's hips and stands up on her tiptoes, eyes sliding shut as soon as their mouths meet. She can taste the wine on Adora's tongue and smell the delicate scent of roses on her, the result of spending the day surrounded by flowers. They're not the first couple to kiss on this bridge, and they won't be the last, but this moment is theirs alone, and Catra wants the whole world to know it.

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It's the last night of the trip, and they spend it in a four-star hotel, one with a spacious lobby and a spotlessly clean indoor pool and a fully stocked minibar in the room. It's expensive for a student's

budget, even in the off-season, but Catra doesn't mind paying her part of the bill. The trip has been nothing short of amazing, and she wants to end it on a high note.

The next day, they take full advantage of the complimentary breakfast, stuffing their faces with eggs and toast and waffles. They linger at their table long after they've finished eating, each nursing a cup of coffee. Catra doesn't want to even think about leaving. Leaving means going home, which is something she simply is not ready for. But this is the bittersweet beauty of unforgettable experiences: they always come to an end too soon, creating a unique time capsule that can't be opened. At least she'll always have the memories, and no one can take them away from her.

They still have a long way back home, so Catra goes down to the lobby to buy snacks for the ride while Adora heads to their room to finish packing. After making sure she has everything they need, Catra makes her way back to the elevators, only to practically collide with someone coming around the corner, both of them too distracted to watch where they're going. Startled and annoyed, Catra opens her mouth for an angry retort, but the words die in her throat when she looks up and realizes that the person standing in front of her is -- Glimmer.

"What the hell are you doing here?" they say in unison, gawking at each other.

"You go first," Glimmer says quickly, before Catra can even open her mouth again.

Catra scoffs, makes a half-hearted attempt to hide her smile. Glimmer is a friend from college; they've known each other for a couple of years. She and her boyfriend Bow were originally Adora's study partners, but now all four of them are close friends. If Catra was completely honest, she would call her relationship with Glimmer a friendly rivalry. They're both stubborn and hardworking and fiercely competitive, and Catra would be lying if she said she didn't enjoy every moment of it.

Catra gives Glimmer a quick rundown of what they've been up to. She ends up rambling a bit, because how can she not? To Glimmer's credit, she listens without interrupting, nodding in the right places.

"So *that's* why I haven't heard anything from you for a while," Glimmer says when she's done. "I was actually starting to get a little worried, you know. You guys usually text me at least once a day."

Catra can't help but smile. Glimmer's not wrong. "Like I said, it was a spontaneous decision. And once we were on the road, we just kind of -- forgot everything else, including our phones."

Glimmer nods. "Right. I mean, the same thing happened to me once we came here."

"Which brings me to *my* question," Catra says. "What are you doing in Plumeria of all places?"

"I'm here with Bow, for our three-year anniversary."

"Really?" Catra knew their anniversary was coming up, but she's only now putting two and two together, which makes her feel slightly embarrassed. "Why didn't you say anything to us at my birthday party?"

"It was supposed to be a surprise for Bow. That's why I didn't tell a single soul. I wanted everything to be absolutely perfect."

"Well, was it?"

Glimmer lets out a dreamy sigh. "Yes. I can definitely understand why they say Plumeria is the perfect holiday destination for couples. It's such a romantic place, if you know what I mean?"

Catra can't help but think about last night, the dinner and the bridge and her own whirlwind of emotions. "I might have an idea."

"So, where are you two headed next?" Glimmer asks.

“Back to Bright Moon,” Catra says. “I don’t think we can miss two weeks of classes in a row.”

“Then you’re going back with us,” Glimmer says in a tone that brooks no objections. “We’re just about to check out and start driving back home.”

“Really?” Catra perks up. This is almost too good to be true. “Well, if you don’t mind--”

“Absolutely not. We insist.”

“*We*?” Catra says, incredulous. “You haven’t talked to Bow yet. He doesn’t even know we’re here!”

Glimmer snorts. “As if he would ever say no to spending time with you guys.”

“Fair enough.” Catra knows for a fact that Adora would jump at the opportunity, too; it’s a no-brainer.

“Hey, I’ll take this to the car,” Glimmer says, lifting the bag she’s carrying. “Meet you guys here in the lobby in thirty minutes?”

“Deal.”

“Great! See you soon!” Glimmer moves past her, heading towards the entrance, whipping her phone out and pressing it to her ear. Catra spins around to stare at her, still processing everything that just happened. She catches a glimpse of Glimmer’s back and hears her say, *Bow, you’ll never guess who I just ran into*, before the automatic doors close behind her, hiding her from view.

Catra blinks before turning around and making her way to the elevators. Sometimes, the universe has a funny way of working things out.

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Catra is about to doze off, her head lolling against the window, when someone drives a fist into her arm, causing her to jolt awake with a gasp.

"Punch buggy!"

"Ow! Glimmer!" Catra gives her the nastiest glare she can muster, rubbing her arm. "What are you, five?"

"I'm *bored*, Catra," Glimmer says. Her hand is back on the steering wheel, which is exactly where Catra wants it to be. "Everybody else is asleep. I need you to keep me company."

"Fine," Catra says, "but I'm definitely not playing dumb road trip games with you."

"*Fine.*"

"Don't tell me you're doing that annoying thing where you parrot everything I say back to me."

Glimmer scoffs, as if the whole idea is ridiculous. "I'm not."

"Good."

For a moment, the only sounds that can be heard are the low hum of the car's engine and the gentle drone of the radio. Catra stifles a yawn and lets her eyes rest on the mountains in the distance, the purple-tinted peaks visible above the muted greens of the tree line. Adora and Bow are asleep in the backseat, Bow slumped against Adora, Adora's temple pressed against the window. There's a bit of drool on the corner of her mouth; Catra wants to wipe it off with the pad of her thumb, press a kiss to her open lips.

"Look at them," Glimmer says softly, eyes lingering on the rear-view mirror. "So adorable."

"I know." Catra allows a smile to touch her lips. It feels good on her face, easy and true and natural. "I love her so much."

Glimmer shakes her head to herself, just a little bit. “I love him so much.”

Catra sinks back in her seat, overcome by a wave of affection. Her love for Adora is like a well-worn sweater, big and warm and comfortable, something she can always wrap herself in. Yes, it has changed shape over the years, but she has always carried it everywhere with her, comforted by the softness and the familiarity of it. It’s all hers, and she doesn’t ever want to lose it.

Catra turns her head and looks out the passenger side window, eyelids heavy. In a few short hours, they’ll be back in Bright Moon. The thought doesn’t bother Catra as much as she expected. If there’s one thing she has learned from this trip, it’s that she can feel at home anywhere, as long as she’s surrounded by the right people. The past week has been life-changing, a beautiful blur of cities and colors and endless stretches of empty roads, but what made the trip truly special was that Adora was there too, sharing the experience with her. Adora might not be aware of it, but she has the ability to light up any space she’s in, at least in Catra’s eyes. She’s a force to be reckoned with, and Catra can’t help but keep falling in love with her.

She’s fighting to stay awake now, body swaying with the motion of the car. The seat heaters are on, and, well, it’s been a long and eventful week. Catra closes her eyes, tells herself that she’s just resting them for a moment. It is, of course, a blatant lie.

“Don’t you dare,” Glimmer says, but there is no real bite in her voice, only fond exasperation.

“Too late now,” Catra says, mumbling. She catches a glimpse of Glimmer’s smile before her eyes slide shut for real and she drifts off to sleep, warm and cozy and more content than she has been in a long time.

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